

stance, has incorporated the traditional Buddhist architectural style of an educational institute or monastery, and has been designed in the Vihara style—with rooms and staircases placed around common courtyards dotted with trees and sitting areas where students from different courses can mingle.

“People dream of such courtyards and the banyan tree (like the Bodhi Tree). We will also place statues of two icons—one of Chanakya and one of the Buddha—on either side of the main courtyard, symbolising the concept of ‘from strategy to mindfulness’. After all, mindfulness is the heritage of this place,” says Sahay.

FRUITS OF LABOUR

To leverage its growing stature and to address the demand-supply gap in the management courses, the institute has increased its offerings. In line with other newer IIMs like the one in Raipur from where Sahay was brought in, it launched a five-year Integrated Programme in Management that includes three years of graduation, followed by a two-year MBA, in 2021. While it started offering its PhD programme in 2019, beginning 2023-25, it will launch two specialised MBA programmes—Digital Business Management and Hospital and Healthcare Management. Together, these courses will take its total student count on campus to over 1,100 this year.

The institute, which operates autonomously now, has 50 permanent faculty members and 18 more will join soon. It is also looking to improve diversity on campus. According to Sabyasachi Mohapatra, Chairperson of its career development cell, apart from encouraging female students, the institute is focussed on ensuring that 30 per cent of students are from non-technology backgrounds. While the current ratio of freshers to ex-



Vinita S. Sahay
Founder Director,
IIM Bodh Gaya

“The perception was that it would take 10-12 years to set up an institute like this, but we had to shake that belief”

30
PER CENT

The proportion of female students on campus; there were no women in the first few batches

80
COMPANIES

The number of firms that went to the campus to recruit students in 2023, up from 30 in 2020

perienced students stands at 50:50, from the upcoming session the share of the latter is set to rise as the institute is looking to increase the average work experience per batch to 36 months from 24 months at present.

CONVINCING PITCH

“The perception was that it would take 10-12 years to set up an institute like this, but we had to shake that belief by constantly pushing for a speedier response from the local authorities. We had to make them believe that an institution like this can be up and running in two-three years,” says Sahay, who was recently reappointed as Director after completing her five-year stint.

It was not just the mindset of the locals that needed a shake-up; parents of aspiring students had to be convinced too. In May 2018, barely two months after Sahay took charge, the first female student enrolled in the institute’s MBA programme. It took a lot of persuasion and a personal assurance from the Director to convince the family of the student, who hailed from Uttarakhand, to allow her to join an institute that did not even have a girls’ hostel at the time. “It took me four and a half hours (to convince them). We made them talk to some of our students from Uttarakhand, [and] I gave them a personal assurance about her safety and well-being,” Sahay recalls. Those efforts paid off. In the next batch, the number rose to three, and it has now scaled to 30 per cent of the total strength on campus.

It’s this habit of breaking the status quo that’s one of the reasons that Sahay chose to extend her tenure at the institute. She feels the task is unfinished and that IIM Bodh Gaya’s journey towards excellence has only just begun. **BT**

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